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Now, don't get the idea that the only worthwhile parts of *Common Stocks and Uncommon Profits* are scuttlebutt and the fifteen points. It's just that I think they are the jewels. There are smaller sparkles, too, bits of wisdom well worn. For example, by 1990 I'd been a professional for eighteen years and fairly successful. I'd been a *Forbes* columnist for six years. Enter Saddam Hussein. As the threat of war grew, investors grew timid. The market buckled. I've studied quite a bit of history and written two financial history books. The history as I saw it said,“Buy.” But I hadn't lived that much history. One weekend, I buttressed my resolve by review-ing Chapter Eight,“Five Don'ts for Investors,” and Chapter Nine,“Five More Don'ts for Investors,” in Part One. And I knew that the war scare had to be a market buying opportunity. From it, along with some of my economic forecasting, came my well-timed late-1990 “buy” columns. Timing that right, when most others were bearish, helped secure my long-term place in *Forbes*, for which I've always been grateful. But you might have found the same things useful more recently as we had the 2000–2002 bear market and what could be thought of as Saddam Hussein II.

As I write, in 2002, we have had the worst bear market since, depending on how you look at it, my early career in 1974 or the Great Depression in 1937–1938. Many have had their faith in prior investment beliefs shattered. Many have developed new-found faith in other concepts that they will soon surely find shallow, vapid, and void of eternal truth.What would my father say looking forward. He would say simply that capitalism will prevail and the United States and the Western world will progress, that you can debate where the market bottom is, and that he rarely considered himself to be very good at that (although he made a few spectacular market calls in his long career). He would say that if you own companies that have the fifteen points and don't get carried away by what he referred to as “fads and fancies,” you will come through this period just fine. He would say that if you don't own stocks, this is a perfectly fine time to buy companies that possess his fifteen points. The bear market of 2000–2002 has seen to that. Might they go lower before they go up? He would always acknowledge that possibility. But he would say that it won't matter much a few years from